

Area of Study 1E – Hinduism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Hinduism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically within families, and with regard to matters of life and death.

There are four sections: Hindu Beliefs, Marriage and the Family, Living the Hindu Life and Matters of Life and Death.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Hindus today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Hindu's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Hinduism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Hinduism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.5)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.4)*

Students should recognise that Hinduism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Judaism, Islam, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Hinduism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Hinduism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Hinduism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Shaivism and Vaishnavism.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of Brahman: The nature of Brahman as spirit, ultimate reality or absolute truth; how the characteristics of Brahman are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Katha Upanishad 2.2.6–8.
1.2	The nature and importance of understanding Brahman as Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman: how Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman are shown in Hindu scripture, for example Nirguna (Taaittiriya Upanishad 2.7.1–2) and Saguna (Rig Veda 1.154.1–2); the nature and importance of Vaikuntha (spiritual worlds); divergent ways in which belief in each may be expressed in the life of Hindus today.
1.3	Three aspects of the divine: Brahman, Antaryami and Bhagavan; the nature and significance of the divine as Brahman (everywhere and non-personal), Antaryami (within the heart) and Bhagavan (beyond, as a personal loving God); how the three aspects are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Mundaka Upanishad 2.1; why belief in the three aspects of the divine are important in Hindu life and for religious pluralism today.
1.4	Manifestations of the Divine: the nature and importance of how the deities are shown in Hindu scriptures; avatars and murti; the nature and role of male deities: divergent understandings of the importance of Vishnu (including Rig Veda 1.22) and Shiva; the nature and role of the female force, Shakti, including Parvati and Lakshmi.
1.5*	The nature of the individual and life within Hinduism: the nature and importance of the atman (eternal self), karma, the cycle of samsara, moksha; divergent Hindu understandings of the nature of the individual and life, including interpretations of Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 4.4; why beliefs about the atman, karma, samsara and moksha are important for Hindus today.
1.6	The purpose of human life for Hindus: the nature and significance of the four aims of life (Purusharthas) – dharma, artha, kama and moksha; the nature and significance of anatana dharma (eternal law), including Bhagavad Gita 3.35; the nature and significance of varnashrama dharma (duties according to materialistic situation in life).
1.7	Hindu responses to suffering, knowledge and ignorance: Hindu teachings about suffering, knowledge and ignorance such as ahimsa, respect, empathy, mind/sense control, humility, and love, including Mahabharata 5.39; divergent Hindu understandings as to why there is suffering, knowledge and ignorance for Hindus today.
1.8	Hindu cosmology: the nature of the Hindu cosmology as shown in Hindu scriptures, including Rig Veda 10.129; the nature and importance of the cycle of four ages (yugas), including descriptions of the Kali Yuga in the Mahabharata, many worlds and their diverse inhabitants; the nature and divergent understandings of the importance of the concepts of prakriti (matter/nature), tri-guna (three qualities) and maya (illusion).